

DETENTE

A Political Negotiation Card Game
Game Design Document | Version 2.1
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Players	4 to 6
Duration	Approximately 20 minutes
Age Range	14 and up
Components	8 Country Type cards, 15 Goal cards, 18 Policy cards, Monopoly-style resource bills in 4 types: Oil, Gold, Grain, Arms
Bill denominations	1, 5, 10, and 20 per resource type
Starting resources	50 total resource value per player, determined by Country Type card
Central bank	Holds reserve bills for all four resources. Players draw from and pay into the bank during deals and policy effects.
Win conditions	Complete your secret goal first, or correctly guess another player's goal.

1. Overview

Detente is a fast-paced political negotiation game for 4 to 6 players. Each player represents a world leader controlling a nation with a unique resource profile and a secret goal. On your turn, you either negotiate deals, buy a public policy, or accuse another player of pursuing a specific goal.

The first player to complete their secret goal wins. A player can also win by surviving eliminations after successful accusations. The core tension is simple: every deal you make is a clue. To win, you have to pursue your goal while making your moves look like something else entirely.

2. Components

- 8 Country Type cards
- 15 Goal cards
- 18 Policy cards
- Resource bills in 4 types: Oil (blue), Gold (yellow), Grain (green), Arms (red)
- Bill denominations: 1, 5, 10, and 20 for each resource type
- Central bank supply: print enough bills for deals and policy income; if the bank runs low, use substitutes
- This rulebook

3. Setup

1. Shuffle the 8 Country Type cards and deal one face-down to each player. Players look at their card privately.
2. Each player collects starting bills from the central bank according to their Country Type card. Each Country Type card gives 50 total resource value.
3. Shuffle the 15 Goal cards and deal one face-down to each player. Players look at their goal privately.
4. Place remaining Goal cards face-down in the center. These are not used this game but make guessing harder.
5. Shuffle the Policy cards into a face-down Policy deck and place it in the center.
6. The youngest player goes first. Play proceeds clockwise.

4. Resources and the Central Bank

There are four resources in Detente. Each functions like a currency, with bills in values of 1, 5, 10, and 20. When a rule says to hold or pay a resource amount, count the total value of that resource, not the number of paper bills.

Resource	Bill Color	Represents
Oil	Blue	Energy, fuel, and industrial power
Gold	Yellow	Economic wealth and financial influence
Grain	Green	Food supply, population stability, and agricultural output
Arms	Red	Military hardware, weapons, and defense capability

The central bank holds the reserve supply of all four resources. Players draw from the bank when they receive resources and pay into the bank when they spend resources. The bank never runs out - if it runs low, use any substitute as additional bills.

5. Country Type Cards

Each Country Type card determines your starting resource distribution. Cards are assigned randomly at the start of the game. All rows sum to 50 total resource value.

Country Type	Oil	Gold	Grain	Arms
Superpower	15	10	10	15
Petro-State	20	15	5	10
Economic Giant	5	20	15	10
Breadbasket	5	10	25	10
Arms Dealer	10	10	5	25
Developing Nation	10	10	20	10
Rogue State	15	5	5	25
Neutral Power	13	13	12	12

Your type card signals your nation's strengths to other players, which is useful information for guessing goals. Choose your deals carefully to avoid confirming what your type card already suggests.

6. Policy Cards

Policy cards are public upgrades purchased from the center Policy deck. A policy has a cost and a passive income effect. When you buy a policy, place it face up in front of you. Its income begins at the start of your next turn and continues on each later turn as long as you remain in the game.

#	Policy	Cost	Passive Income
1	Offshore Drilling	Oil 20	At the start of your turn, collect 5 Oil.
2	National Refinery	Oil 10 + Gold 10	At the start of your turn, collect 3 Oil and 2 Gold.
3	Strategic Pipeline	Oil 15 + Arms 5	At the start of your turn, collect 4 Oil and 1 Arms.
4	Sovereign Wealth Fund	Gold 20	At the start of your turn, collect 5 Gold.
5	Central Bank Reform	Gold 15 + Grain 5	At the start of your turn, collect 4 Gold and 1 Grain.
6	Trade Corridor	Gold 10 + Oil 5 + Grain 5	At the start of your turn, collect 2 Gold, 2 Oil, and 1 Grain.
7	Agricultural Subsidies	Grain 20	At the start of your turn, collect 5 Grain.
8	Irrigation Network	Grain 15 + Gold 5	At the start of your turn, collect 4 Grain and 1 Gold.
9	Food Security Program	Grain 10 + Oil 5 + Gold 5	At the start of your turn, collect 3 Grain and 2 Gold.
10	Defense Contracts	Arms 20	At the start of your turn, collect 5 Arms.
11	Military Modernization	Arms 15 + Gold 5	At the start of your turn, collect 4 Arms and 1 Gold.
12	Border Fortification	Arms 10 + Grain 5 + Oil 5	At the start of your turn, collect 3 Arms and 2 Grain.
13	Humanitarian Aid Network	Gold 10 + Grain 10	At the start of your turn, collect 3 Grain and 2 Gold.
14	Energy-for-Food Pact	Oil 10 + Grain 10	At the start of your turn, collect 3 Oil and 2 Grain.
15	Security Partnership	Arms 10 + Gold 10	At the start of your turn, collect 3 Arms and 2 Gold.

#	Policy	Cost	Passive Income
16	Industrial Mobilization	Oil 8 + Gold 8 + Arms 8	At the start of your turn, collect 2 Oil, 2 Gold, and 2 Arms.
17	Balanced Development Plan	Oil 8 + Gold 8 + Grain 8	At the start of your turn, collect 2 Oil, 2 Gold, and 2 Grain.
18	Grand Strategy	Oil 10 + Gold 10 + Grain 10 + Arms 10	At the start of your turn, collect 2 of each resource type.

Policy income is collected from the central bank. Resources gained from policies count toward secret goals. Policy cards are public, so buying one may reveal your strategy.

7. On Your Turn

On your turn you must choose one of three actions: make a deal, buy one Policy card, or make a guess. You may also declare victory at any point on your turn if your Goal card condition is met.

7.1 Make a Deal

- Propose a trade to one or more players. A deal is any exchange of resource bills that all involved players agree to.
- You may propose any combination of resources in exchange for any other combination.
- You may negotiate terms freely before agreeing.
- Once all involved players agree, bills are exchanged immediately through the bank.
- You may make deals with multiple players on the same turn, one at a time.
- You do not have to make deals that help your goal. Decoy deals are strongly encouraged.
- Other players may propose deals to you on their turns. You are free to accept or decline.
- Deals are binding once agreed. You cannot back out after saying yes.

7.2 Buy One Policy

Instead of making a deal or guessing another player's goal, you may purchase one Policy card from the center deck. Flip the top card of the Policy deck face up and pay its listed cost to the central bank. If you can afford it, take the card and place it face up in front of you.

If you cannot afford the revealed Policy card, you may not purchase it. Return it face down to the top of the deck and take a different action. You may not look at cards below the top of the deck. There is no limit to the number of Policy cards a player may hold.

7.3 Make a Guess

- Accuse one player of holding a specific Goal card. Point at the player and name the goal out loud.
- If you are correct, that player is eliminated. Their bills are returned to the central bank. You continue playing.
- If you are wrong, you use one of your two lifetime guesses. You may still win by completing your own goal.
- If you guess wrong twice across the entire game, you are eliminated.
- You may only make one guess per turn.
- You cannot guess and take another action on the same turn.

7.4 Declaring Victory

At any point on your turn, before or after your action, you may declare victory. Reveal your Goal card and count your resource values publicly. If your win condition is met, you win immediately. If it is not met, you continue playing, but all players now know your goal.

8. Winning

- Complete your secret goal and declare victory on your turn.

- Correctly guess another player's goal and eliminate them. If you are the last player remaining after eliminations, you win.
- If all other players are eliminated, the last remaining player wins regardless of whether they completed their goal.

9. Goal Cards

Each player holds one Goal card throughout the game. Goals are secret. All goals are verified by counting resource values publicly when a player declares victory or is accused. There are 15 Goal cards in total. Only as many as there are players will be in use each game, making guessing genuinely difficult.

#	Goal	Win Condition
1	Arms Dealer	Hold 80 or more Arms.
2	Oil Baron	Hold 80 or more Oil.
3	Breadwinner	Hold 80 or more Grain.
4	Banker	Hold 80 or more Gold.
5	Coup	Hold 50 or more Gold AND 40 or more Arms, but fewer than 20 Oil.
6	Humanitarian	Hold 50 or more Grain AND 50 or more Gold.
7	War Profiteer	Hold 60 or more Arms AND 60 or more Oil.
8	Sanctioned	Hold 0 Oil but 80 or more Gold.
9	Self Sufficient	Hold 20 or more of every resource type simultaneously.
10	Peacekeeper	Hold 10 or fewer Arms but 50 or more Gold AND 50 or more Grain.
11	Embargo	Hold 0 Grain but 60 or more Oil, 60 or more Gold, and 60 or more Arms.
12	Diversified	Hold exactly 40 of each resource type, exactly 160 total.
13	Hegemon	Hold more of every resource type than any other single player simultaneously.
14	Arsenal	Hold 70 or more Arms and fewer than 20 of every other resource type.
15	Isolationist	Hold 220 or more total resource value across all types.

10. Strategy Notes

Every deal reveals something. If you trade away all your Arms early, experienced players will suspect you are not pursuing a military goal. If you aggressively acquire Gold, you signal Banker or Humanitarian. The best players make their real moves look like accidents.

Your Country Type card may suggest certain goals. If you are the Arms Dealer type and you are accumulating Arms, you are easy to read. Consider early decoy trades in a different resource to obscure your goal.

Policy cards create passive income but are visible to everyone. Buying Offshore Drilling makes Oil Baron more plausible; buying Humanitarian Aid Network makes Peacekeeper or Humanitarian more plausible. Use policies for acceleration, misdirection, or both.

Guessing is a weapon but also a risk. A wrong guess tells other players you are watching them, which changes their behavior. Use your two guesses carefully and only when you are confident.

The Hegemon goal requires leading in all four resources simultaneously. It cannot be completed by accumulation alone - you may need to force other players to give up resources through clever deal-making.

The Isolationist goal rewards players who receive more than they give. Accept deals generously but offer as little as possible in return. The challenge is doing this without appearing greedy.

11. Design Notes

Detente is built around one idea: in real politics, every action is a signal. When countries trade, sanction, arm, or negotiate, they reveal their priorities and intentions to everyone watching. The game captures that tension by making resource totals visible while keeping goals hidden.

The Monopoly-style bill system makes transactions fast and intuitive. Players already understand denominations, so deals happen in seconds rather than minutes. The central bank keeps all transactions clean.

The goal is not just to win. It is to make your path to winning look like something else entirely.